

Black Mirror Episode Writing Program

Program Introduction

Black Mirror is a television series about technology, society, and human behavior.

Its episodes often begin with a new technology that seems useful, entertaining, convenient, or harmless. The story then explores how people use it, how institutions react to it, and what happens when its effects become difficult to control.

The technology does not need to be completely realistic today. It should, however, feel like something that could exist in the near future.

A strong episode is not simply about an evil machine.

The technology usually reveals or magnifies an existing human problem, such as:

- The desire for popularity
- Fear of loneliness
- Loss of privacy
- Addiction to entertainment
- Pressure to succeed
- Dependence on artificial intelligence
- The desire to avoid grief
- The need to control other people
- Fear of being forgotten
- The willingness to trade freedom for convenience

The purpose of this program is to create an original episode about a new technology and its effect on a person, family, school, workplace, community, or society.

The student should begin with one simple question:

What would happen if a useful technology became too powerful, too common, or too difficult to escape?

The episode should contain a clear beginning, a growing problem, a major turning point, and an ending that forces the audience to think.

The ending does not need to be happy. It should reveal the true cost of the technology or the decisions made by the characters.

The student does not need to write a full television screenplay immediately. Most assignments may be answered with a paragraph, a short list, a character profile, a scene, or a simple diagram.

The final product will be an original episode outline, short story, comic, video, or screenplay.

Taskings

Task 1: Choose a Human Problem

Select one human behavior or social problem that the episode will explore.

Examples include:

- Wanting everyone to like you
- Spending too much time online
- Comparing yourself to others
- Avoiding difficult emotions
- Believing everything an algorithm recommends
- Allowing technology to make personal decisions
- Recording every moment of life
- Replacing real relationships with artificial ones
- Punishing people forever for past mistakes
- Giving companies too much personal information

Write one sentence explaining the chosen problem.

Task 2: Invent the Technology

Create one new device, service, application, or system.

Explain:

- What it is called
- What it does
- Why people want it
- Who created it
- How people access it

The technology should initially appear helpful.

Task 3: Create the Main Character

Describe the person most affected by the technology.

Include:

- Name
- Age
- Occupation or role
- Main goal
- Main fear
- Personal weakness
- Reason for using the technology

The main character should want something understandable.

Task 4: Show the Technology Working Well

Describe the beginning of the episode.

Show how the technology improves the main character's life.

Examples may include:

- Helping the character make friends
- Improving school or work performance
- Preventing mistakes
- Making money
- Protecting the family
- Removing painful memories
- Predicting danger
- Making everyday decisions easier

The audience should understand why the character trusts it.

Task 5: Introduce the First Warning

Create one small event showing that the technology may have a hidden problem.

The warning should not immediately destroy the character's life.

Possible warnings include:

- The system gives strange advice
- Private information appears in public
- The technology misunderstands someone
- A person becomes dependent on it
- A company changes the rules

- The device refuses to turn off
- The algorithm begins influencing relationships
- Someone without the technology is treated unfairly

Explain how the main character responds.

Task 6: Make the Problem Grow

List three ways the situation becomes worse.

For each problem, explain:

- What happens
- Who is affected
- Why the character does not simply walk away

The character may be trapped by money, reputation, law, fear, addiction, family pressure, or social expectations.

Task 7: Create the Choice

Give the main character a difficult decision.

The choice should involve a cost.

Examples include:

- Keep using the technology or lose an important opportunity
- Reveal the truth or protect the family
- Delete the system or lose access to someone they love
- Obey the algorithm or become an outsider
- Expose the company or risk punishment
- Save one person while harming many others
- Protect privacy or accept greater safety

Explain both sides of the choice.

Task 8: Write the Turning Point

Write a short scene where the main character realizes the true danger.

The scene should include:

- A new discovery
- A strong emotional reaction
- A decision
- A consequence that cannot be easily reversed

This is the moment when the story changes direction.

Task 9: Choose the Ending

Select one type of ending.

Warning Ending

The main character escapes, but the technology continues spreading.

Tragic Ending

The character loses what they were trying to protect.

Twist Ending

The audience learns that the situation was different from what it appeared to be.

Victory With a Cost

The character stops the immediate problem but sacrifices something important.

Society Accepts It

The technology is harmful, but society decides that the convenience is worth the cost.

Uncertain Ending

The audience is left unsure whether the character made the correct decision.

Explain what the audience should feel at the end.

Task 10: Write the Final Image

Describe the final image or final scene of the episode.

It should communicate the episode's main idea without requiring a long explanation.

Examples include:

- A child receiving the same device
 - A deleted account quietly reactivating
 - A crowd repeating the same harmful behavior
 - A company launching an improved version
 - A character smiling while clearly trapped
 - A warning message being ignored
 - The technology spreading to a new country
 - A machine making one final unexpected decision
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Task 11: Name the Episode

Create a short title.

The title may refer to:

- The technology
- A phrase used in the episode
- A company slogan
- A human emotion
- A hidden meaning
- The final scene

Write one sentence explaining the title.

Task 12: Build the Episode Outline

Write a simple outline using the following structure:

Opening

Introduce the character, the world, and the technology.

Success

Show why the technology becomes valuable.

Warning

Introduce the first sign of danger.

Escalation

Make the problem increasingly difficult to escape.

Discovery

Reveal the true nature or cost of the technology.

Choice

Force the character to make a difficult decision.

Ending

Show the result and the final message.

Optional Episode Planning Sheet

Episode Title

Human Problem

Technology

Main Character

What the Character Wants

How the Technology Helps

First Warning

Major Consequence

Difficult Choice

Ending

Final Image

Main Lesson or Question

Dashboard Tracking

The developmental dashboard only needs to record:

- Task completed
- Date completed
- Effort level
- Main idea explored
- Main lesson learned
- Next task
- Optional parent or mentor comment

The dashboard does not need to judge whether the student reached the “correct” conclusion.

The purpose is to examine technology from several angles and explain the consequences of human decisions.

Final Project

At the end of the program, the student should produce one of the following:

- A complete episode outline
- A short story
- A screenplay

- A comic
- A storyboard
- A video episode
- An audio drama
- A mock documentary
- A technology advertisement followed by the real story
- A presentation explaining the episode and its warning

The student should also answer three final questions:

1. What human weakness did the technology magnify?
2. At what point could the disaster have been prevented?
3. Would people still use the technology after seeing what happened?

The central rule remains:

The technology creates the opportunity, but human choices create the story.